

Utilitarianism Is Demanding, But Utilitarians Need Not Demand

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TODO (Singer)

1 Moral Prescription and Moral Demanding

Utilitarianism, like many moral theories, is commonly understood as prescribing certain actions as morally obligatory. In classical act utilitarianism, an agent ought to perform the action that maximizes overall utility in a given situation. This prescription is obligatory, regardless of what the relevant action is, and particularly, it is never supererogatory, no matter how demanding it is. This prescription is also normative, stemming directly from the utility maximization principle. The act of demanding that others perform such actions, however, must be distinguished from this prescription.

Moral prescription, in this essay, refers to the evaluative standard set by a moral theory regarding what an agent ought to do. *Moral demanding*, however, refers to the interpersonal or social act of requiring, pressuring, or blaming an agent for failing to meet that standard. Moral demanding is fundamentally distinguished from moral prescription in that its existence owes to a particular moral agent. Prescription is the application of the moral theory to a particular action or a situation. For act utilitarianism, this means applying the utility maximization principle, which should be thought of as a fundamentally logical process. On paper, the prescription should be independent of who is performing the application, as the principle should ideally take every single information about all agents in question. Thus, moral prescription is theoretically an agent-independent process, with practical disagreements caused by epistemic imperfections of agents.

In contrast, moral demanding is a social action, done from a moral agent to another. Particularly, as an action of a moral agent, moral demanding is itself subject to evaluation according to the moral theory. To suppose otherwise, that moral demanding is exempt from moral evaluation, can have detrimental effects; indeed, even coercive or violent attempts to impose one's moral standards can be understood as forms of moral demanding. The next section applies this statement to act utilitarianism, and explores its consequences with respect to the demandingness objection.

2 The Morals of Demanding

The demandingness objection implicitly assumes that we should demand of each other the utility-maximizing action, which exceeds what our intuitions may suggest. Indeed, several interpretations of Singer's work imply that the vast majority of humans is "evil" in the utilitarian sense. This is supported by the standard utility-maximization principle: to not live in a marginal-utility state necessarily decreases overall utility, not meeting the obligatory standard. Orthogonal to the question of what utilitarianism prescribes, however, is that of how moral agents ought to relate to one other given such prescriptions.

The problem of this assumption is that in general, demanding is also an act subject to moral evaluation, and there is no reason to assume that the moral theory prescribes such demanding. As a counterexample, we describe a situation in which the utility-maximizing action of one person is different from the utility-maximizing form of demanding of a bystander. Consider a person A, a person heavily dependent

on alcohol and prone to violence under influence. We assume that their alcohol consumption causes enough harm that the global utility is decreased by their alcohol consumption. Clearly, act utilitarianism prescribes them not to consume alcohol in this case. However, for a bystander B, it may not be optimal for B to demand complete soberness of A: such a harsh demand is likely to fail in actually keeping A sober, or even lead to strong withdrawal symptoms. To maximize long-term utility, therefore, B might be obligated to gradually decrease A's alcohol consumption; this might have a higher chance at stifling A's violent behavior more quickly. As such, what is morally obligated of A does not equal what is morally obligated of B to demand of A.

This has important implications for the demandingness objection: utilitarianism *cannot* prescribe agents to make such harsh demands upon others, if this act is not itself utility-maximizing. For example, if a sufficiently large number of people are discouraged by the fact that the morally correct action far exceeds their immediate willingness to change their course of action, that they effectively forfeit even trying to improve, then the societal utility improvement might not be optimal. What might be better is to impose a lower bar upon humanity, one which more people would be willing to attempt at achieving. We do not attempt to characterize such an optimum in this essay; the point is that, in at least some cases, the demandingness objection targets not the moral criterion itself, but the epistemic and practical assumptions involved in enforcing it. In such cases, making harsh moral demands is plausibly not itself utility-maximizing.

Works Cited

Singer, Peter. "Famine, affluence, and morality." *Applied Ethics*, Routledge, 2017, pp. 132–42.